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Hula: Women Tell the Tale

It should be prefaced:

This is a holistic telling. In this paper, I intend to relay all my tenderly gathered knowledge about the Kānaka Maoli *Native Hawaiians* with an emphasis on the women's perceivable hand in preserving history and tradition within the sacred dance: hula. Embodying the same energy, I will also be telling a story; a love story about my Nana and her lovely hula hands.

The women of my life are never further than a kāholo. In hula, the kāholo is a move consisting of two directional steps finished with a small tap of the foot. It began with my sister. I would watch her every freckle move and contort so that I could replicate the expressions with my phantom beauty marks. The shadow only grew as the sun rose. She rode horses; I want to ride horses. She played volleyball; sign me up for the club! She danced hula; I must dance hula, just as my sister, my Nana, and my kūpuna *ancestors* before me.

In traditional Hawaiian culture, children are meant to listen and observe. They are encouraged to think rather than question. Traditions are sacred; they are not meant to be changed or altered. They are shared but only under the utmost respect. The native Hawaiians lacked a written language. The hula kahiko na mo'olelo *ancient stories hula*, paired with the oli *chants*, encodes Kanaka Maoli's poetic history. Unlike many other ancient civilizations that recorded their stories in tangible preservation, the history and legends of the Kanaka are maintained in the ceremonial dance.

I have seen my Nana dance very few times. I was seven when I first watched her sway across the stage. Her hips didn't move like mine and her arms weren't as straight, but I had never seen - and still have yet to see - beauty like her dancing. Her face told so much more story than mine. Her curves were so much more evident. Her grace is undeniable.

Hula was a ritual. There was an elite group of dancers that would be selected to train and reproduce the dances that reveled chiefs and held the creation of the cosmos. Native female chiefs were hunted "...for their exalted blood lines traced back to the gods..." (Kaeppler 189). The powerful women would arrange and perform poetic pieces intended to pay homage to the gods and kūpuna. It was a great honor to be chosen to carry on the heritage.

The hula dancer is the interpreter of the nation's past. The dancer's entire physique is engaged to produce an image. The hands, feet, expressions, and eyes unite to tell a story. The Kanaka

were a poetic people. Embalmed by awe, they enshrined forms of nature, like light and the ocean, as gods. Deeply connected to their surrounding earth, the Hawaiians used natural phenomena to express human emotions. They humbly invited the gods to the hulas in celebration of them.

The Hawaiians worshiped many deities. The goddess of hula is Laka. It is her spirit that is prayed to possess the dancer. Traditional hula dancing begins with prayers and altars to the gods. Associated with light and rain, they ask for inspiration from Laka. It is the spirit of Laka that knits together the mana *energy* of hula dancers. They are united in respect, devotion, and diligence to the spirit.

Adrienne L. Kaeppler tells the story of “Two Hawaiian Dancers and their Daughters”. Keahi Luahine is a renowned Kaua’i hula dancer. Kawena and her adopted daughter, Patience (or Pat), were prophesied by Keahi’s dreams to carry the hula tradition of Keahi’s ancestral line. Luahine needed Kawena to learn her ancestors’ ways to keep them from being lost. The two students studied both the “...‘olapa ‘dancing part of the tradition’...” and “...the ho’opa’a ‘playing the musical instruments and singing/chanting’ part of the tradition...” (Kaeppler 191). They began lessons with a ceremony of kapu *taboo*, to wrap the pupils in the sacred art. And ended the day’s instruction with “the special noa ‘kapu ‘freeing’ chant” (Kaeppler 192). The dancer must earnestly align themselves with the ethos of Laka.

Sanctioned by Keahi, the two dancers were sent to many kumus hula *hula teachers* to study. There is a Hawaiian saying, ‘a ‘ohe pau ka ‘ike i ka hālau ho’okani , that means “not all knowledge is retained in one school”(Kanaoekana). The Kanaka were guided by their stories. Keahi conceded to the need for as many narratives to be passed down as possible. And acknowledging the honorable duty, Kawena and Pat were sedulous throughout all of their teachings. Though Pat was a shy dancer and let her sister, Pele, take over performing, she saw

her kuleana *responsibility*. Out of the limelight, Pat continued to impart the traditions once bestowed upon her.

Now I rewatch my Nana's dance on home videos. I map her moves in the mirror as the dance plays on loop. I hear her voice echo from inside the deep freezer in the garage. She asks if I'm hungry. She floats past with the scent of orchid and coconut flour. She dances by like the island breeze; ferocious wind found content. I reread her story again and again.

During the nineteenth century, Hawaii was colonized by the Mormon missions. Hula produced various new interpretations. Some deemed it a pagan ritual; the converted-Christian Queen Ka'ahumanu banned hula in public places. While others consumed it as art and celebrated its beauty. King David Kalākaua ignited a national revival with hula being an "anti-imperial" (Hajibayova & Buente 1) movement in the late 1880s. The king had a personal court of hula dancers for any occasion. The grandeur of his birthday jubilee is remembered today by the Merrie Monarch Festival. It is with great pride and acclaim that hālaus hula *hula schools* make the trip to perform on the main stage. Rehearsals echo the ways of traditional rituals. Women memorize the stories in hula and chant; preserving history in their hips and hands. King Kalākaua is honored with the perpetuation of indigenous Hawaiian traditions, language, and arts in Hilo once a year with a week-long festival similar to the weeks-long cultural celebration his jubilee had once been.

The hula woman is more than a solar-powered swayer. Though her figure has been slimmed and trimmed in the Western study's lens, her spirit is unscathed. Beautiful stories are told and retold in dance. Sometimes the dance is just to admire enchanting nature. Most times, it is aloha *love* that must be kinetic. Queenie Ventura Dowset, a warrior in the keeping of Kanaka tradition, trained with a private troupe growing up. She stressed, "If you can feel, if you can make contact with the story, the person, you can be that." She was taught by a kumu who she had first

mistaken as a spirit. Entranced and rendered by the power their pedagogue danced with, Queenie and other carefully selected students sought to center themselves in the dance of hula. Queenie relays her kumu's teaching, "If you study yourself, you can displace yourself." The physical body may be dancing, but the soul is elevated. The art of hula is not lonesome in moves alone, a dancer must harness their entire being; "You, yourself, must believe you are as good as you can be." (Queenie).

Kahili Long Cummings of Maui was immersed in hula from the get go. With 15 children, her mother, a kumu hula herself, made sure each of the seven sisters knew the art well. Auntie Kahili grew an affinity for the expression. Her mother taught her tradition but the dance taught her passion. She expresses a love for the community it provided her. Ideas were shared and practiced. Kahili now observes the evolved methods with appreciation. Though they differ from her original teachings, she finds beauty in the movement. It is a full-body commitment. The entire being must move. Potential energy has no place in hula; love must be an action taken.

I am not my sister's shadow, nor a mimicry of my Nana; I am an image of their story. I examine and contemplate the lessons they share. I practice their steps with intention and admiration. I mindfully transpose their many tales within my own. I am their surviving library.

New generations of Hawaiians sing the songs of their kūpuna today. Native roots reverberate out of tradition. The hallowed practice of observation is perpetuated. From the Merrie Monarch Festival to hula danced in the confines of a dorm, the spirit of the Kānaka Maoli lives on with fervor.

The mainland USA mistook the gift of hula as an invitation to paradise. They found the dance to be perfectly decorative for their tropical cocktails and corporate escape. Its inevitable diaspora made it subject to fetishization by the overworked Dreamer American. But the same woman who was carved down to see permanence from a car's dash, does not sway for you or me. She dances

for the teachers that ushered her. She dances for the Nana, with the lovely hula hands. And she dances to honor all the other kūpuna that she has to thank for where she is now. She is the culmination of the stories that came before her and the stories she decides to make for herself. She preserves her past with a tap, and shares her future with intentional steps.

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